



CITY OF SOUTH MILWAUKEE CIVIC GRANTS COMMISSION MEETING

AGENDA

Thursday March 19, 2026 5:00 PM
2424 15th Avenue, South Milwaukee, WI
Committee Room

1. Call to order.
2. Approval of May 7, 2025 minutes.
3. Update on 2025 Bucyrus Civic Grant recipients.
4. Consideration of eligible nonprofit requests to apply for 2026 Bucyrus Civic Grant funding.
5. Schedule next meeting.
6. Adjourn.

Public Notice

There is a potential that a quorum of the Common Council may be present at this meeting. Upon reasonable notice, a good faith effort will be made to accommodate the needs of disabled individuals through sign language, interpreters or other auxiliary aid at no cost to the individual to participate in public meetings. Due to the difficulty in finding interpreters, requests should be made as far in advance as possible, preferably a minimum of 48 hours. For additional information or to request this service, contact the South Milwaukee City Clerk at 414-762-2222 or write to the ADA Coordinator, City Hall, 2424 15th Avenue, South Milwaukee, Wisconsin 53172. The City of South Milwaukee is TDD equipped and can be accessed by calling 414-768-8060.



CIVIC GRANTS COMMISSION MEETING MINUTES

May 7, 2025

1. Call to order/Roll Call.

The meeting was called to order at 5:30 p.m. Commissioners present: Aleta Schilling, Ald David Bartoshevich, Dave Kieck, Melissa Ellis and Ericka Lang.

2. Approval of March 18, 2025 meeting minutes.

Schilling moved to approve the minutes, seconded by Ellis. Vote unanimous.

3. Presentations by civic grant applicants.

Lang reviewed the presentation schedule. The Bucyrus Civic Grant Program has an annual fund amount of \$50,000. Seven nonprofits/government agencies applied for the grants totaling \$74,740.

Human Concerns requests \$10,000, the Bucyrus Museum requests \$4,360, Friends of South Milwaukee Public Library requests \$21,380, Growing South Milwaukee request \$8,000, MARM Education Center request \$27,000, the South Milwaukee Historical Society requests \$7,000 and the South Milwaukee Celebrations Committee requests \$5,000.

4. Discussion/possible motion to recommend approval of Bucyrus Civic Grant applications.

Commissioners discussed each request, modifying and reducing allocations to utilize the annual funding and carryover balances from the previous grant cycle.

Ellis motioned to approve the following funds, seconded by Schilling:

- \$6,985 to Human Concerns for professional grant writing services
- \$2,100 to Friends of the South Milwaukee Library for two video player systems and games
- \$8,000 to Growing South Milwaukee for a storage shed and port with rainwater collection and solar for community gardens
- \$25,000 to MARM Farm for a self-contained urban growing unit for sustainable hydroponic farming and education, located in South Milwaukee
- \$6,950 to South Milwaukee Historical Society to purchase a standard scanner, purchase a flatbed scanner for oversized documents, purchase acid-free storage drawers for large files
- \$4,500 to South Milwaukee Celebrations Committee for professional services to organize and market an inaugural jazz music event at the Bucyrus Commons downtown event space.

5. Update on 2024 grant recipient projects.

Lang stated several nonprofits did not utilize all the funds and the unspent funds would carry over into the 2025 fund balance. Bartoshevich left the meeting at 7:55 pm.

6. Adjourn.

Ellis motioned to adjourn the meeting at 7:59 pm, seconded by Kieck. Vote 4-0.

Recorded by Ericka Lang

**South Milwaukee Civic Commission
Bucyrus Civic Grant Awards 2025**

update 3-16-2026

Actual Expenses		
1 Human Concerns		
\$6,985		Hire professional grant writer
2 Friends of the South Milwaukee Library		
\$2,100	\$2,581	Purchase video player & games for young adults/children
3 Growing South Milwaukee		
\$8,000		Build storage shed and port with rainwater collection and solar for community gardens at 1308 Milwaukee.
4 MARM Farm		
		Convert 40-foot shipping container into SCUGU- self-contained urban growing unit for sustainable hydroponic farming, also used for education. Half of produce will be donated to Human Concerns
\$4,000		Purchase/delivery of shipping container
\$18,500		Purchase hydroponic units, solar panels, rainwater system
<u>\$2,500</u>		Purchase classroom equipment
\$25,000		
5 South Milwaukee Historical Society		
\$600	\$635	Replace printer/scanner for faster scanning
\$3,850	\$4,351	Purchase flatbed scanner for oversized photos/documents 12"x17"
<u>\$2,500</u>	<u>\$2,077</u>	Purchase acid-free horizontal 5-drawer storage for large files
\$6,950	\$7,064	
6 City fo South Milwaukee Celebrations Committee		
		Create new music event "South Milwaukee Jazz & Gospel Fest" at Bucyrus Commons
\$1,500	\$1,395	Professional services: Advertising and marketing
\$2,500	\$2,500	Professional service contract for management services
<u>\$500</u>	<u>\$965</u>	Additional services or equipment
\$4,500	\$4,860	

\$53,535

\$50,000 Annual Fund. 2024 unspent grant funds \$3535 were carried over into 2025 grant cycle

South Milwaukee 2026 Bucyrus Civic Grant Letters of Interest

3/16/2026

Organization	Request Amount	Notes
1 Art Works	\$10,000	Contract for professional grant researcher/writer
	<u>\$5,000</u>	Contract for professional marketing and mural experience services
	\$15,000	
2 Bucyrus Museum	\$2,460	Create digital display for archived former Bucyrus employees and numerous print publications: \$2130 Lenovo ThinkPad laptop & \$150 Microsoft Home office license
	<u>\$1,270</u>	Replace (8) storage shelving with (5) wheeled racks
	\$3,730	
3 South Milwaukee Friends of the Public Library	\$6,000	Create a Household Tool Lending Library: acquire tools and storage set up
4 South Milwaukee Historical Society	\$240	Purchase (6) fireproof storage boxes w/ acid-free portfolios
	\$3,500	Purchase fireproof 2-drawer lateral filing cabinet
	\$270	Purchase microphone, halo light and video creation software
	<u>\$4,360</u>	Purchase (2) 36"x24" Gaylord horizontal flat files and b.
	\$8,370	
5 South Milwaukee Police Department	\$3,500	Create a Ring Doorbell Camera Program. Purchase 50 Ring Doorbell cameras.
6 First Responders Children's Foundation - ServPro	NA	New South Milwaukee scholarship for a student who lost a parent during line of duty.
Total Fund Requests	\$36,600	

Art Works

So Mke Downtown Mural Initiative



February 27th 2026

Dear Bucyrus Civic Grant Committee,

On behalf of ArtWorks, the Growing South Milwaukee Mural Committee, we are requesting \$15,000 through the Bucyrus Civic Grant Program to help move our mural initiative into its next phase - one that is more sustainable and structured for long-term success.

We understand how important it is that Bucyrus funds are used in ways that build independence rather than ongoing reliance. That thinking shaped this request.

\$10,000 - Hiring a Grant Researcher/Writer

We would like to hire a professional grant researcher/writer to help us identify and pursue additional funding sources for future murals.

Our committee is made up of committed downtown business owners who have successfully organized fundraisers and completed multiple murals. What we don't have is professional grant-writing expertise or the time to chase larger opportunities properly.

We've connected with Laura D' Amato, the Chief Development Officer for the Racine Art Museum to better understand how bringing in a consultant can help us build real funding capacity. We see this as the smartest investment we can make to reduce future dependence on local donors and grant cycles.

\$5,000 - Marketing & Building the Mural Experience

We are also requesting \$5,000 for professional marketing and promotional support.

We continue to believe in the idea of creating a destination experience through a walkable Mural Tour. While growing and sustaining downtown takes time and persistence, we remain committed to doing our part to create energy and momentum.

With this funding, we would:

- Add QR codes to murals so visitors can learn about the artist and the story behind each piece
- Strengthen our digital presence in preparation for organized and self-guided Mural Tours
- Explore partnering with the South Milwaukee Garden Tour to incorporate mural stops into the annual June event
- Begin exploring how our Mural Tour could be promoted as part of the Lake Michigan Circle Tour, expanding our reach to regional visitors

The art is there - now we need help telling the story in a more professional, consistent way.

Art Works

So Mke Downtown Mural Initiative



We are proud of what we've accomplished so far and believe we have demonstrated responsibility, follow-through, and a genuine commitment to benefiting the South Milwaukee community.

Thank you for considering our request and for your continued investment in our city.

Sincerely,

Darlene Piszczek
ArtWorks/Mural Committee
1001 Milwaukee Ave
South Milwaukee, WI
414-935-8705



**South Milwaukee
Industrial Museum LLC**
P.O. Box 84
South Milwaukee, WI 53172-0084



February 24, 2026

Ericka Lang
Economic Development Department
2424 15th Avenue
South Milwaukee, WI 53172

Subject: Letter of Interest for the 2026 South Milwaukee Bucyrus Civic Grant Program

Dear Ericka,

The Bucyrus Museum hosts many local and out of area guests each year during various times including our scheduled days, Great Lakes Cruise Line visitors, weddings, corporate events, civic events, funeral luncheons, tour groups, and continuing education group events.

We currently have a printed spreadsheet book that identifies former Bucyrus employees for guests to browse. We would like to be able to update and expand use of the information in the books by building a digital display that not only includes the employee spreadsheet, but a scanned copy of the original industrial relations employee sign-up ledger that currently resides behind our display case for visitors to browse. We would also link our searchable digital copies of the *SCOOP*, *Excavating Engineer*, and *Booming World* Bucyrus published magazines along with roughly 11,000 machine photo images in our picture index for guests to enjoy. We would include the ability for guests to print a reasonable number of these pages in black and white at no charge.

We are seeking grant help in accelerating the new display construction by acquiring the core of the interactive display, a robust PC to be able to host the data and be able to quickly retrieve the requested information for viewing. We already have a compatible printer and stand-alone screen to use. The PC would also require a one-time Windows Office license to be able to process the document scans and photo images for viewing. Cost required for us to start this initiative is \$2,130.00 for one Lenovo ThinkPad X1 Gen 13 14" laptop and \$150.00 one Microsoft Home Office single license, plus tax and shipping bringing the total grant request to \$2,460.00. This would be a great new interactive display area for our museum where visitors and self-direct their own search for machine or family member history.

We are also in need of greatly improving our use of the very small third floor storage space. The footprint is currently consumed by eight (8) 60" x 12" x 30" shelving units inherited from the original museum in 2016. We have outgrown these and they no longer hold an adequate amount of our archived and duplicate materials as the collection has grown in the last 5 years. The other obstacle facing expansion of our storage needs is the top of the elevator shaft machinery deck which consumes roughly ¼ for the small third floor footprint. This area is suitable only for framed item storage due to weight restrictions.

Our second request is to replace the 8 smaller units with five (5) heavy duty, 5 tier 60"x 24" x 72" wire racks in the same space that would double our current capacity. These units are twice the shelf space and on wheels, so aisle spacing can be easily compressed and then expanded when we need to retrieve or store items. These are available locally from Costco at \$240.00 each. Total grant request for the five units including tax (no shipping required) is \$1,270.00.

Total for the two 2026 museum initiatives being requested is \$3,730.00. Please advise if one or both of these can be moved forward for consideration. Thanks!

Sincerely,

Robert Jelinek

Director

January 24, 2026

Bucyrus Foundation

c/o City of South Milwaukee

South Milwaukee, WI

Re: Letter of Interest – Household Tools Lending Library Project

Dear Bucyrus Civic Grant Program Review Committee,

On behalf of the Friends of the South Milwaukee Public Library, I am pleased to submit this letter of interest expressing our desire to apply for funding through the Bucyrus Foundation Grant Program. We seek financial support to establish the Household Tool Lending Library, a collection of household and specialty tools and equipment for South Milwaukee Library users to borrow. This initiative directly supports community engagement, reduces financial barriers, encourages sustainable practices through sharing, and aligns with the Bucyrus Foundation's commitment to enhancing quality of life for South Milwaukee residents.

All adult South Milwaukee residents can benefit from this free resource with their library card. The funding request for our proposal is \$6,000; this includes acquiring the household tools and providing appropriate storage and maintenance. This funding amount would provide a great collection of household tools for the library at a capacity that can be maintained and circulated. During our experience running the Repair Café at the Library we heard from attendees that they would love to be able to borrow tools instead of having to purchase them or rent them. We can provide more examples of requests in a full proposal but some of the tools requested by attendees; soldering station, specific drill attachments, cutting tools, Dremel, etc. In addition, library patron requests have been recorded by library staff which will be used to assemble an informed and relevant collection.

The addition of the Household Tool Lending Library to the library's collection will strengthen an already valued community asset and further the library's mission to serve as a hub for learning, creativity, and connection. We appreciate your consideration and welcome the opportunity to submit a full proposal with detailed project plans and budget. Please feel free to contact us with any questions or requests for additional information. Thank you for your continued investment in South Milwaukee and for considering our request.

Sincerely,



Monica L. Rodriguez Morris

President, Friends of the South Milwaukee Public Library

787-688-1587

friendsofsmkepl@gmail.com



South Milwaukee Historical Society

717 Milwaukee Avenue

South Milwaukee WI 53172

City of South Milwaukee
Bucyrus Civic Grant Program
Economic Development Department
2424 15th Avenue
South Milwaukee, WI 53172

February 27, 2026

Greetings:

The South Milwaukee Historical Society (established in 1972) is aware of the responsibility that our non-profit 501(c)3 organization has to the City of South Milwaukee. It is our hope to reach more of our citizens by offering more services and opportunities to learn and enjoy the rich history of our city.

Our 2026 goals include:

- a) Digitize collections - We continue to identify, scan, and archive the documents and artifacts in our files at the museum. Depending on the collection, the digital files would be published on our website for viewing or stored on the Historical Society computer for future use and research. After the items are scanned, we need to create a safe storage system for artifacts, original documents, and digital media.
- b) Video-record Historical Society events and presentations so they will be available for viewing on our website and for use in future programs.
- c) Continue improving safe storage of oversized photographs and maps.

To help meet these goals, it is our desire to acquire eligibility to apply for the City of South Milwaukee Bucyrus Civic Grant. The funds would be utilized in the following ways:

- 1) Purchase acid-free storage portfolios and fire-proof storage for artifacts and digital records. Purchase fireproof 2-drawer lateral filing cabinet for storage of original documents.
- 2) Purchase a wireless microphone, halo light, and software to produce the video presentations.
- 3) Purchase flat storage files to protect oversized photographs and maps.

Our preliminary budget includes:

Fireproof storage boxes (6) with acid-free portfolios	\$ 240
Fireproof 2-drawer lateral filing cabinet	\$3,500
Microphone (\$40.00) Halo Light (\$80.00) Video creation Software (\$150.00)	\$ 270
Gaylord Horizontal Flat files (2) 36" x 24" plus Base	<u>\$4,360</u>
Total amount requested:	\$8,370

We look forward to offering better access to our archives and enhanced website content, as well as better storage for the items entrusted to our care. All digitized documents will be made available to the public for viewing and research - both online and at our museum. Thank you for this opportunity to help us achieve our goals.

Best regards,

Richard G. Thinnes, President
South Milwaukee Historical Society
414-520-1285 southmilwaukeehistory@gmail.com



SOUTH MILWAUKEE POLICE DEPARTMENT

2424 15th Ave, South Milwaukee, WI 53172

Phone: (414) 768-8060 | Fax: (414) 768-8067 | www.smpolice.com



February 18, 2026

South Milwaukee Police Department
Captain Dan Fournier
2424 15th Ave
South Milwaukee, WI 53172
dfour@smwi.org
414-768-8060 ext. 174

Economic Development Department
Ericka Lang
2424 15th Ave
South Milwaukee, WI 53172

Dear South Milwaukee Civic Grant Commission,

I am submitting this letter of interest for the 2026 Bucyrus Civic Grant Program.

The South Milwaukee Police Department's Mission Statement is "In partnership with the community, we strive to enhance the quality of life through the reduction of crime, fear, and disorder." A major component of our mission statement is partnering with the community and its members. One of our department's goals is to continuously build and strengthen our relationship & partnership with our community. We do this in many ways, from hosting community events to establishing programs for the betterment of our community, ensuring that our community members feel safe.

The South Milwaukee Police Department would like to start a new program to enhance our community residents feeling of safety and security. Our department would like to start a Ring Doorbell Camera Program for the residents of South Milwaukee. This program would provide Ring Doorbell Cameras to the residents of South Milwaukee that do not already have Ring Doorbells or another type of residential camera for their residence. This new program would benefit both the residents of South Milwaukee and the South Milwaukee Police Department. Residents that apply and are awarded a Ring Doorbell, from the police department, would have an added layer of security for their residence. The South Milwaukee Police Department would benefit from adding more video camera surveillance to our city. Video footage has become a crucial part of solving crimes that occur. It is our belief that the residents that receive cameras from us would be happy to share footage, if we requested it from them.

The South Milwaukee Police Department is therefore applying to the 2026 Bucyrus Civic Grant Program for \$3500.00. This would enable us to purchase approximately 50 Ring Doorbell Cameras from Ring to kick off this new program. Once we have this program established, we would intend on applying for this grant in future years to expand the program.



SOUTH MILWAUKEE POLICE DEPARTMENT

2424 15th Ave, South Milwaukee, WI 53172

Phone: (414) 768-8060 | Fax: (414) 768-8067 | www.smpolice.com



I would be happy to provide further details about this new program, if the City's Civic Grant Commission decides that the South Milwaukee Police Department's program gets to continue on in the grant application process.

In closing, I am respectfully requesting that the City's Civic Grant Commission consider the South Milwaukee Police Department to be a recipient of the 2026 Bucyrus Civic Grant.

Thank you,

Captain Dan Fournier

Captain Dan Fournier
Administrative Services Captain
South Milwaukee Police Department



The Mission: Beyond the Green

On June 5, 2026, the Milwaukee and Waukesha business communities will gather for the First Responders Event. While the day is a local celebration of the men and women who serve our communities, the true purpose is much more profound. We are raising critical funds for the First Responders Children's Foundation (FRCF), an organization dedicated to providing a path forward for the children of fallen hero

Our New Approach for 2026: Mission-First Fundraising

In previous years, like many charity outings, much of the focus was on covering the substantial overhead of the event itself. This year, we have fundamentally changed our model. By moving the event to Muskego Lakes Golf Club, we have reduced our per-person golf costs by over 50%. We have also eliminated non-essential expenses to ensure that our fundraising activities are driving donations for the Foundation's mission, not simply covering the cost of the event. Our goal is to move every possible dollar from the "expense" column to the "impact" column.

The Strategic Ask: The Bucyrus Legacy Scholarship

Because of this lean operational shift, we are asking the Bucyrus Foundation to anchor our 2026 efforts by sponsoring a Higher Education Scholarship to be delivered on the day of the event. We are not asking the Foundation to sponsor a hole or a beverage cart; we are asking you to underwrite a child's future.

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Investing in South Milwaukee's Future

We are particularly excited to share that this year's scholarship is being designed specifically to support a local South Milwaukee student. To ensure this support reaches the most deserving candidate, we are collaborating directly with a dedicated leadership team:

Police Chief Bill Jessup (South Milwaukee PD)

Fire Chief John Litchford (South Milwaukee FD)

Travis Punt, Chief Revenue Officer for the First Responders Children's Foundation

Together, we are identifying candidates within our own town who have been impacted by the loss or injury of a first responder parent. This scholarship will:

Directly Fund a Student: 100% of your grant will go toward the tuition and fees of a South Milwaukee student.

Restore Opportunity: Provide a tangible, life-changing moment for a family in our immediate neighborhood, ensuring the financial burden of education does not follow the tragedy of loss.

Establish a Legacy: Tie the historic Bucyrus name—a symbol of South Milwaukee's industrial strength—directly to the academic success and resilience of a local hero's child.

Visibility and Media Promotion

We recognize the importance of the Bucyrus Foundation's role as a pillar of our region. To honor this partnership, we are committing to a high-visibility media strategy:

Local Media Blitz: We will coordinate with local affiliates (CBS 58, WTMJ, and the Milwaukee Journal Sentinel) to feature the "Bucyrus Legacy Scholarship" announcement as the centerpiece of the event's coverage.

The Presentation: During our dinner program, we will invite a representative from the Foundation to personally present the scholarship award alongside our local Chiefs.

Digital Narrative: Your support will be highlighted in all digital marketing, including our social media campaigns and the FRCF national impact reports.

Conclusion

We have done the hard work of cutting costs to ensure this event is a true fundraising vehicle. We now invite the Bucyrus Foundation to be the engine of that vehicle. Let's ensure that on June 5th, we aren't just celebrating a game of golf—we are celebrating the future of a student right here in South Milwaukee.

CITY OF SOUTH MILWAUKEE

The City received seven Letters of Interest from local nonprofit organizations totaling \$97,312 in proposed projects.

The annual grant budget is \$50,000 with five nonprofits receiving funding.

2024 South Milwaukee Bucyrus Civic Grant

Awards Nonprofit

Amount

Art Works

Mural along 907 Milwaukee Avenue west elevation		
Exterior lighting and 3D elements	\$2,000	\$2,000 Unspent
Equipment rental	\$500	
Materials (tools, paint, drop cloth)	\$5,500	
Labor	<u>\$14,000</u>	
	\$22,000	

Warm Up South Milwaukee

Establish Program & Install 3 Automated External Defibrillators	\$9,000	\$1131.05 unspent
Launch Winter Coat Program for Lakeview Elementary	<u>\$2,400</u>	
	\$11,400	

Friends of South Milwaukee Library

3 tablets for childrens area	\$2,100	\$404.54 unspent
3 child-sized computer stations	\$5,700	
2 lounge sofas for childrens learning area	<u>\$5,800</u>	
	\$13,600	

Friends of Mill Pond

2-sided post & panel educational kiosk with canopy and installation, located near Milwaukee County Warming House	\$2,000	\$2,000 unspent
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South Milwaukee Historical Society

Dedicated Laptop Computer for public Ancestry research	\$600	
Dedicated Printer for public Ancestry research	<u>\$400</u>	
	\$1,000	

Total \$50,000

CITY OF SOUTH MILWAUKEE

2023 Bucyrus Civic Grant Awards

The City received 11 Letters of Interest from local nonprofit organizations totaling \$917,800 in proposed projects.

The annual grant budget is \$50,000 with seven nonprofits receiving funding.

Nonprofit	Amount	Project
South Milwaukee Police Department	\$5,000	New K9 unit program
Friends of Grant Park	\$1,600	New trail entry signs at Seven Bridges, for educational, wayfinding, work progress announcements, and relevant County and City information maintained by the FOGP.
South Milwaukee Lions Foundation	\$6,000	New and upgraded electrical service for Lionsfest event space
Bucyrus Museum	\$1,825	Large format scanner for scanning historical collections and contributing to "Recollection Wisconsin Program" online catalog
Friends of the South Milwaukee Library	\$16,300	Create a multi-use lab and learning space to enhance technology and training opportunities; Create a more friendly post-coronavirus children's play area for ages 6 and under.
South Milwaukee Historical Society	\$4,500	Create a new website and new Ancestry subscription.
Warm Up South Milwaukee (South Milwaukee firefighters)	\$14,775	Develop plan for new senior extinguisher program and future nonprofit projects; purchase apartment-size fire extinguishers; coaching and consulting for implementing program.
	\$50,000	